

BRIEF

Global Copper Market: Production & Trends

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METALS SECTOR BRIEF — GLOBAL COPPER MARKET: PRODUCTION & TRENDS

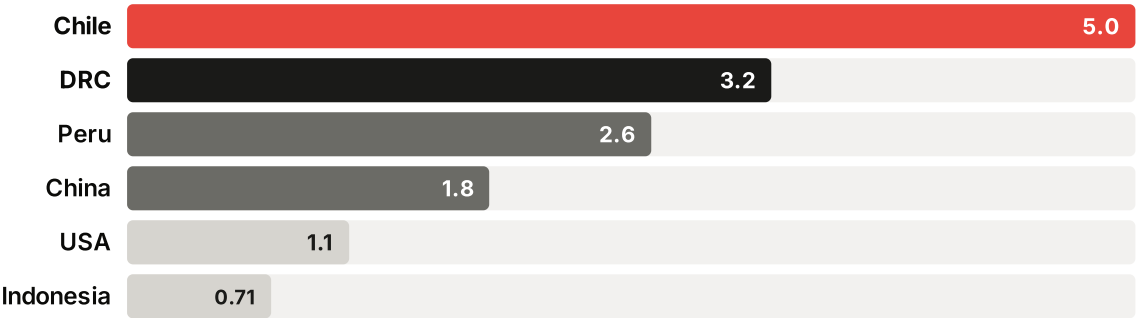
14million tonnes

Impending copper supply shortfall by 2040

Copper is headed for a structurally tight market through 2040 as energy-transition demand rises faster than mine supply can expand, creating an impending 14 million tonne shortfall and intensifying price and security-of-supply pressures.

Chile leads 24.8 Mt global copper supply, but a widening deficit against 42 Mt projected 2040 demand makes energy-transition sectors the decisive growth driver.

2025 MINE OUTPUT BY COUNTRY (MT)

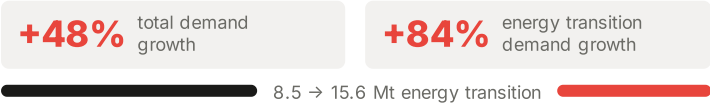
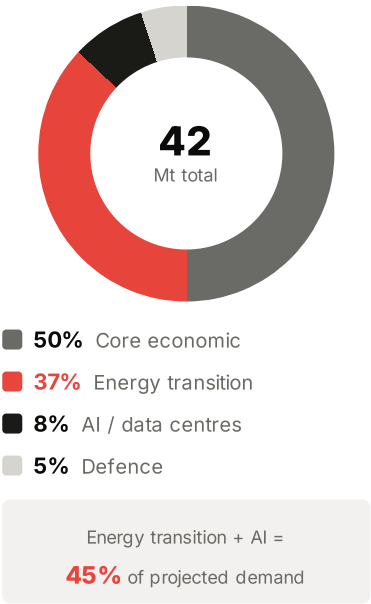


▲ DRC overtakes Peru as 2nd-largest producer

DEMAND TRAJECTORY 2025-2040



2040 DEMAND COMPOSITION



● Global supply ≈ 24.8 Mt | ● 2025 demand ≈ 28.4 Mt | Supply gap widening →

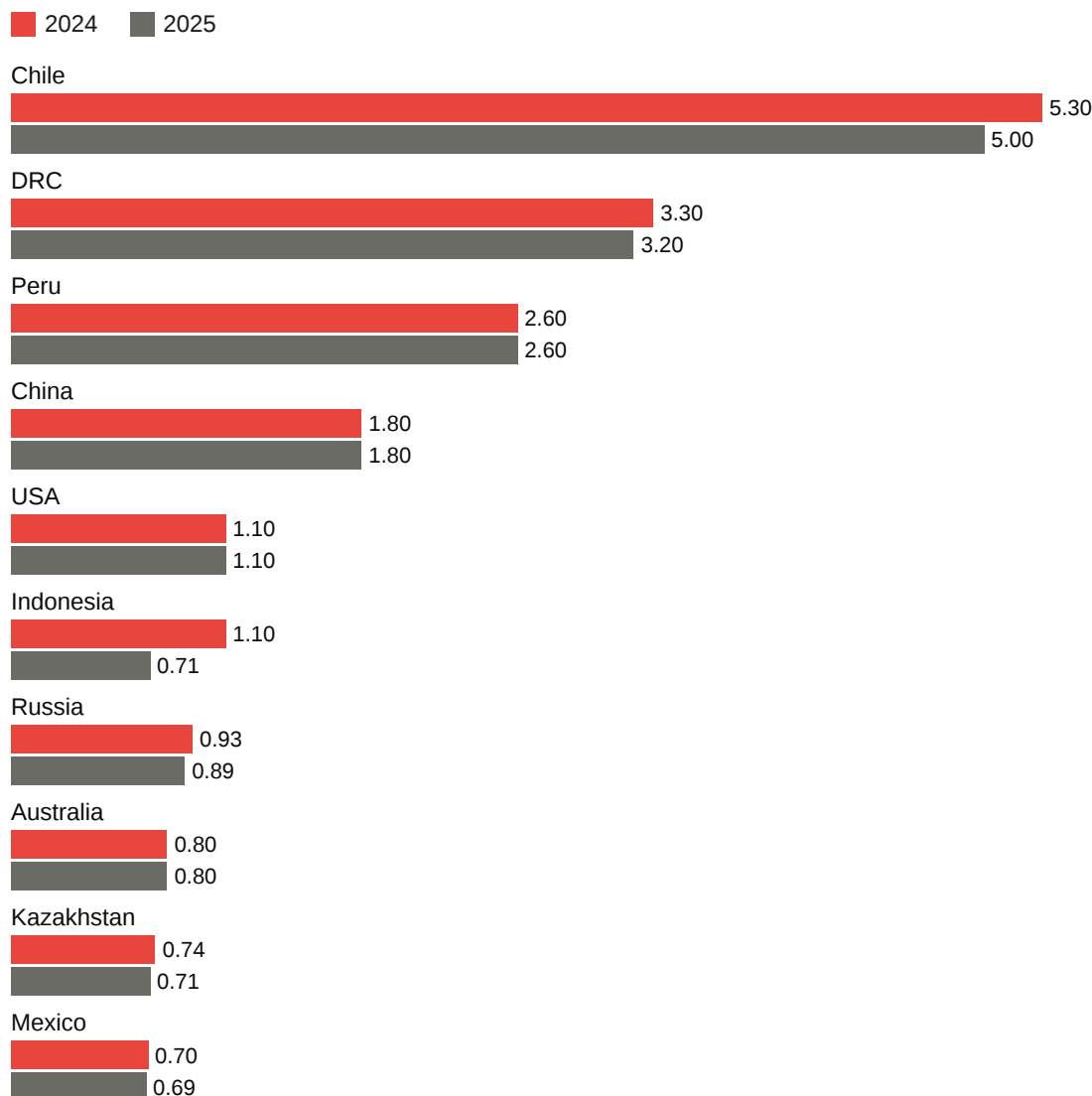
01 Global Production Landscape

Global mine supply remains highly concentrated: USGS estimates 2025 output at about 24.8 Mt, led by Chile at 5.0 Mt, the DRC at 3.2 Mt, Peru at 2.6 Mt and China at 1.8 Mt, with the USA and Indonesia both near 1.1 Mt and Russia, Australia, Kazakhstan and Mexico rounding out the top ten ^{1 2}. For 2024, the same ranking broadly held, with Chile at 5.3 Mt, DRC 3.3 Mt, Peru 2.6 Mt, China 1.8 Mt, USA 1.1 Mt, Indonesia 1.1 Mt, Russia 0.93 Mt, Australia 0.80 Mt, Kazakhstan 0.74 Mt and Mexico 0.70 Mt ^{1 3}. Chile still dominates on reserves and scale, but the DRC has become the clear No. 2 producer and the fastest-rising major supplier, while Peru remains the third pillar of mined copper supply ^{1 2}.

Title — Projected Mine Output for Select Countries in 2024 and 2025 (in Megatons)

COUNTRY	2024 MINE OUTPUT (MT)	2025 MINE OUTPUT (MT)
Chile	5.3	5.0
DRC	3.3	3.2
Peru	2.6	2.6
China	1.8	1.8
USA	1.1	1.1
Indonesia	1.1	0.71
Russia	0.93	0.89
Australia	0.80	0.80
Kazakhstan	0.74	0.71
Mexico	0.70	0.69

Source: Caspr analysis.



Mine output in million tonnes (Mt). Scale max: 5.5 Mt.

02 Historical Shifts in Production

Since 2000, the biggest structural change has been the rise of the DRC from a secondary producer into a top-tier copper power, while Peru expanded strongly through large mine builds and China steadily increased domestic mine output and, even more importantly, downstream processing capacity ^{2 4 5}. Chile remains the largest producer, but its mined output has largely plateaued around the 5.0-5.7 Mt range over the last decade as ore grades declined, mines aged and project complexity increased ^{1 6}. UNCTAD notes that from 2000 to 2024 the DRC's share of global copper mine output rose from about 1% to 14%, Peru's from 7% to 11%, and China's from 5% to 8%, while Chile's production fell about 5% over the same long period despite retaining first place ².

03 Energy Transition and Demand Drivers

Copper demand is being pulled simultaneously by EVs, renewable power, grid expansion and digital infrastructure, with the IEA saying copper records the largest absolute volume growth among key energy minerals, adding about 7 Mt by 2040, and with demand in its Net Zero pathway rising roughly 50% by 2040^{7 8}. S&P Global projects total copper demand rising from about 28.4 Mt in 2025 to roughly 42 Mt in 2040, driven by four vectors: core economic demand, the energy transition, AI/data centers and defense, with energy-transition demand alone rising from 8.5 Mt in 2025 to 15.6 Mt in 2040^{9 10}. BHP similarly expects transport's share of copper demand to rise from around 11% in 2021 to over 20% by 2040 as EV adoption scales, while data-center copper demand could increase six-fold by 2050 as AI lifts electricity use¹¹.

04 Supply Constraints and Price Outlook

The market outlook remains structurally tight: S&P Global estimates a 10 Mt copper supply shortfall by 2040, while its broader framing says an additional 14 Mt of supply will be needed by 2040 to satisfy demand growth^{12 10}. The IEA reported record copper prices in 2026 alongside severe smelter margin pressure, with TC/RCs collapsing as concentrate supply tightened; it also highlights declining ore grades, capital inflation and rising project complexity as core barriers to bringing on new mines fast enough^{6 13}. In practical terms, the industry faces a double squeeze through 2035-2040: demand is accelerating faster than mine development timelines, while permitting, water, power, social license and lower-grade deposits are making new greenfield supply slower and more expensive^{6 12}.

05 Geopolitical Risks and Strategic Implications

Copper supply-chain risk is no longer just about mines; it is increasingly about processing control and export policy. The IEA says China accounted for more than 90% of global copper-smelting capacity growth since 2005 and reached about 50% of global smelting output by 2025, while its share of refined copper production was about 45% in 2024 and is set to keep rising on the current pipeline^{5 14}. Policy risk is also broadening across producing states: the DRC moved in August 2026 to ban exports of copper and cobalt concentrates, while USGS documents recent export controls or bans by China, Zimbabwe and Mozambique across critical minerals, refined metals or scrap streams that affect wider metals security and processing economics^{15 1}. For business, the implication is clear: supply security now depends on diversification across mine origin, smelting/refining geography and trade-policy exposure, not simply access to copper units in the ground^{5 6}.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Copper is headed for a structurally tight market through 2040 as demand outpaces supply growth.
- The DRC has rapidly overtaken Peru to become the second-largest copper producer after Chile.
- Supply security now depends on diversifying mine sources, processing capacity, and trade-policy exposure, not just ore access.

A Study on global copper production and demand would cover supply-gap scenarios, geopolitical processing and export risks, and demand growth from energy transition sectors — run it from your dashboard.